

# Anti-Revolutionary Roads?

## The Political Effects of Belgium's Workmen's Trains

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### ABSTRACT

Between 1885 and 1910 Belgium built one of the world's densest light rail networks, partly as an instrument of political containment: the governing Catholic and Liberal parties hoped that letting workers reach city jobs while living in the countryside would shield them from the rising socialist movement, while the socialists hoped the same connectivity would carry their ideas into the hinterland. Using newly assembled archival data on the network, demography, commuting, and local elections, we develop a quantitative spatial political economy model of location, commuting, and political choices to adjudicate between the two views. Because the political effect runs partly through the endogenous reallocation of the electorate, we identify it from the unexpected component of light-rail-induced gains in job market access and show that the network moved location and commuting alone, leaving wages and rents unchanged. It modestly tempered urbanisation, lowering agglomeration populations by up to two percent, yet raised socialist vote shares where access improved most. Aggregated through the D'Hondt seat allocation rule, the network accounts for three parliamentary seats that passed to the left rather than the Catholics, slimming the governing majority from a counterfactual thirteen seats to seven. The incumbents' counter-revolutionary instrument, in short, modestly hastened the rise it was built to forestall.

*Keywords:* transport infrastructure; market access; economic geography; political mobilisation; socialism; urbanisation; economic history.

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